



Arvind Krishna

Chairman, President & Chief Executive Officer, IBM

1911

IBM founded

\$21B

2025 revenue

\$12.5B

GenAI book of business

93%

Fortune 500 on IBM hybrid cloud

52,000

Jan 2026 agent investigations

01 Who You're Meeting

Arvind Krishna — Chairman, President & Chief Executive Officer, IBM, IBM Consulting.

In role: CEO since April 2020; Chairman since January 2021

Today: Sets IBM's overall direction, including how the Consulting arm is repositioned — he has publicly described consulting as embracing disruption, an acknowledgement that the traditional delivery model is under pressure from the technology IBM sells.

A researcher who rose to run the company. He joined IBM in 1990 at the Thomas J. Watson Research Center and spent twenty-five years in research and technical leadership before becoming Senior Vice President in 2015, running IBM Cloud & Cognitive Software and IBM Research. He was the principal architect of the Red Hat acquisition, the largest in IBM's history. Consulting under him is deliberately coupled to IBM's own stack — watsonx, Red Hat, automation and Z.

Career: Chairman, IBM; Chief Executive Officer, IBM; Senior Vice President, IBM Cloud & Cognitive Software and IBM Research, IBM; Research and technical leadership, from the Thomas J. Watson Research Center, IBM

Education: PhD, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign; BTech, Indian Institute of Technology Kanpur

The company: IBM's services arm, at over \$21B of 2025 revenue. It is the clearest example in this set of a consultancy restructuring its own delivery model around AI agents: Consulting Advantage lets IBM consultants build and manage agent teams, and Enterprise Advantage now sells that capability to clients.

What they sell: Strategy, technology and operations consulting, systems integration and managed services, closely coupled to IBM's own stack — watsonx, Red Hat OpenShift, automation and the Z mainframe platform. Delivery runs on Consulting Advantage internally and Enterprise Advantage for clients.

02 Where The Company Sits

Ali describes the new consulting model as a live dashboard where humans monitor digital workers and vice versa — which is a materially different proposition from selling consultant days, and worth understanding whoever a PortCo ends up using. The volume claim behind it is specific: 52,000 investigations completed in January alone using this approach. The structural consideration for any buyer is that IBM Consulting is tightly coupled to IBM's own stack, so a recommendation arriving through this channel will tend toward watsonx, Red Hat and Z.

03 Talking Points

- Advice arriving through IBM Consulting is not vendor-neutral — it tends toward watsonx, Red Hat and Z. He would not dispute that; ask directly what the alternatives were.
- He has conceded publicly that consulting is being disrupted, which makes a conversation about outcome-based rather than day-rate pricing a live one.
- For a PortCo with an existing IBM estate, he is the escalation point that makes consulting and software commitments move together.

What to pressure-test about the company:

- Consulting revenue grew only about 1.5% in 2025 — from roughly \$20.7B to over \$21B — well behind Accenture's 7%
- Tightly coupled to IBM's own stack, so advice arriving through this channel is not vendor-neutral
- Consulting has been flat in some recent periods; the acceleration is recent and narrow

04 GIP Context

GIP: No publicly disclosed GIP relationship. The most likely entry point is an existing IBM technology footprint at a PortCo — mainframe, Red Hat or watsonx — with consulting following the estate rather than being selected independently.

BlackRock: No publicly disclosed operating relationship; standard index holdings of IBM only.

Others at IBM Consulting: Mohamad Ali (Senior Vice President, IBM Consulting)

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